



A Pragmatic Analysis of English Discourse Markers: Functions and Their Role in Negotiating Meaning

BY

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CHAPTER 1: INTRODUCTION

1.1 Background of the Study

Discourse markers (DMs) constitute an indispensable linguistic mechanism in human communication, functioning as structural brackets that manage information exchange and interpersonal alignment. In English linguistics, items such as well, you know, I mean, actually, and anyway have transitioned from being viewed as stylistic filler words to recognized pragmatic devices that guide conversational processing.

Schiffrin (1987) established that discourse markers operate across multiple planes of talk, including exchange structures, action structures, idea structures, and participation frameworks. Within second language (L2) academic environments, the mastery of these pragmatic markers reflects a learner communicative competence and fluency in negotiating meaning during collaborative dialogue.

1.2 Statement of the Problem

Despite extensive theoretical research into discourse markers within native speaker corpora, empirical investigations focusing on Pakistani ESL tertiary learners remain scarce. L2 speakers often encounter challenges in employing discourse markers appropriately, resulting in conversational breakdown, abrupt topic shifts, or unintended pragmalinguistic infelicities during academic discourse.

1.3 Research Objectives

1. To identify the frequency and distribution of specific English discourse markers in ESL student interaction.
2. To analyze the pragmatic functions performed by discourse markers in managing conversational turn-taking, topic transition, and hedging.
3. To examine the communicative challenges and pragmatic transfers observed among Pakistani ESL learners during meaning negotiation.

1.4 Research Questions

1. What is the quantitative occurrence of selected discourse markers in the academic spoken corpus of AWKUM ESL students?
2. How do ESL learners utilize discourse markers to negotiate meaning and mitigate face-threatening acts during peer interactions?
3. What pedagogical implications emerge for integrating pragmatic discourse markers into English language teaching curricula?

1.5 Significance of the Study

This research provides critical empirical insights for applied linguists, curriculum developers, and ESL educators seeking to enhance pragmatic instruction in higher education. By documenting naturalistic spoken interaction, the study illuminates the nuanced ways learners employ linguistic markers to establish mutual intelligibility.

CHAPTER 2: LITERATURE REVIEW

2.1 Conceptual Definition of Discourse Markers

Discourse markers are sequentially dependent elements which bracket units of talk and convey procedural rather than conceptual meaning. Fraser (1999) classifies discourse markers into contrastive, elaborative, inferential, and temporal categories, asserting that their core role is to establish a pragmatic relationship between the host utterance and prior discourse context.

Unlike content words, discourse markers do not alter the propositional truth value of a clause. For example, omitting the marker *well* in an answer does not change the factual content of the response, yet it eliminates vital metacommunicative cues signaling conversational hesitancy or prospective disagreement.

2.2 Pragmatic Frameworks: Schiffrin and Fraser

Schiffrin (1987) seminal coherence model posits that discourse markers index utterances to both the speaker and the listener across simultaneous communicative planes. In this model, markers like *you know* invite addressee alignment, while *I mean* acts as an internal repair token signaling self-correction.

2.3 Functional Taxonomy in Spoken Interaction

In conversational analysis, discourse markers serve three primary overarching functions: textual, interpersonal, and cognitive. Textual functions encompass topic management, turn-taking coordination, and sequential organization of complex arguments in ongoing discourse. Markers such as *anyway* or *so* signal closure of subordinate tangents and re-orient the conversational focus back to the core thematic agenda.

Interpersonal functions regulate social distance, solidarity, and face management. By utilizing epistemic hedging markers like *I mean* and *you know*, speakers soften assertive declarations, thereby mitigating potential conflict and encouraging collaborative meaning negotiation.

2.4 Discourse Markers in L2 Learner Corpora

Corpus-based studies (e.g., Aijmer 2002, Müller 2005) reveal notable discrepancies between native and non-native deployment of discourse markers. L2 speakers often exhibit overreliance on a narrow inventory of familiar markers while underutilizing subtle interactive hedges, often resulting from prescriptive classroom instruction that overlooks pragmatic discourse routines.

CHAPTER 3: RESEARCH METHODOLOGY

3.1 Research Design & Approach

This study employs a mixed-methods descriptive and corpus-linguistic design to investigate both quantitative frequencies and qualitative pragmatic functions of English discourse markers in student interaction.

3.2 Corpus Sampling & Distribution

The dataset comprises 25 audio-recorded group discussions and seminar presentations conducted among undergraduate students enrolled in the Department of English at Abdul Wali Khan University Mardan.

Table 1: Distribution of Corpus Samples Across Academic Interaction Modules

Interaction Module	Sessions	Participants	Duration	Words
Academic Seminar Presentations	10	20	180 mins	12,450
Peer Group Discussions	10	30	150 mins	10,820
Classroom Debates	5	15	90 mins	6,530
Total Corpus Aggregate	25	65	420 mins	29,800

3.3 Data Coding & Analytical Procedures

Recorded verbal interactions were transcribed verbatim following standard conversation analytic transcription protocols (Jefferson 2004). Target discourse markers were extracted, tagged, and coded in accordance with Fraser functional taxonomy.

To establish inter-rater coding reliability, two independent applied linguistics researchers coded a 20% random subsample of the transcripts. Cohen Kappa coefficient achieved a value of $k = 0.88$, demonstrating high statistical consistency across coding judgments.

3.4 Ethical Considerations

Informed written consent was obtained from all participants prior to recording sessions. Anonymity was preserved by assigning alphanumeric pseudonyms to all speakers, and participants were assured that data would be used exclusively for scholastic analysis.

CHAPTER 4: DATA ANALYSIS AND FINDINGS

4.1 Quantitative Frequency of Selected Discourse Markers

Corpus query analysis revealed a total of 1,142 discourse marker tokens across the 29,800-word dataset, corresponding to an overall normalized density of 38.3 tokens per 1,000 words.

Table 2: Frequency and Percentage Distribution of Discourse Markers in Spoken Corpus

Discourse Marker	Freq (f)	Percentage	Per 1k	Primary Functional Domain
Well	348	30.5%	11.7	Turn-initiation & Hesitation marker
You know	284	24.9%	9.5	Interpersonal alignment & Common ground
I mean	212	18.6%	7.1	Self-repair & Message reformulation
Actually	165	14.4%	5.5	Contrastive assertion & Factuality
So / Anyway	133	11.6%	4.5	Sequential progression & Topic transition
Total Tokens	1,142	100.0%	38.3	Academic Spoken Discourse Aggregate

4.2 Qualitative Analysis of Pragmatic Functions

Qualitative micro-analysis revealed that *well* predominantly served as an epistemic delay device, allowing speakers to structure responses during cognitively demanding peer interactions.

Furthermore, the marker *you know* operated as a vital pragmatic hedge, invoking shared communal understanding and reducing the risk of face loss during contentious academic debates.

Speakers utilized *I mean* to perform real-time communicative repairs when encountering lexical retrieval difficulties, indicating that L2 speakers actively rely on discourse markers to negotiate intelligibility in collaborative academic settings.

CHAPTER 5: CONCLUSION AND RECOMMENDATIONS

5.1 Summary of Findings

This study investigated the pragmatic distribution and functions of English discourse markers among ESL learners at Abdul Wali Khan University Mardan. Findings demonstrate that discourse markers are critical instruments for managing conversational floor, repairing misunderstandings, and fostering interpersonal alignment.

5.2 Pedagogical Recommendations

Language educators should shift from treating discourse markers as superfluous hesitation fillers toward explicit pedagogical instruction on their pragmatic utility in academic spoken discourse.

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